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Microsoft brings its contact-centre AI to rivals' platforms. New York City proposes a route to a human.

Weekly summary · 25 October 2026

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MICROSOFT

Microsoft brings its contact-centre AI to rivals' platforms, in public preview.

- Microsoft launched Contact Center Intelligence in public preview on 21 October. It takes the AI agents and quality scoring from Dynamics 365 Contact Center to other vendors' contact centres.
- Microsoft names Five9, Cisco Webex Contact Center and Avaya. Its customer Siemens Healthineers says it layers the product onto its Genesys and ServiceNow platforms.
- Microsoft says its quality agent will "Evaluate both agentic and human-led interactions" against one standard. It says the agent reviews past bot conversations today, with real-time scoring "coming soon".
- Microsoft says the agents are "usage-based through Copilot Credits". It has published no price list. It says help for human agents and live coaching will be "available soon".

> Our view: Microsoft is separating the AI from the contact centre. The host vendor keeps the human seat, while Microsoft bills its AI by use. Watch: prices at Microsoft's Ignite conference, 17 to 20 November.

SOURCES Microsoft, 21 Oct · CXM, 23 Oct

NEW YORK CITY

New York City proposes that customer-service bots offer a route to a human.

- New York City's consumer agency proposed on 20 October that bots disclose they are automated. Without "a single-step transfer mechanism", such as "Press 0", and the estimated wait, a firm would be presumed in breach.
- Firms would keep logs of bot conversations for three years. Each year they would report how many were resolved without a transfer, and how many customers came back within 72 hours.
- Gothamist reports, citing the agency, that fines would start at $525 and that the rule would apply to any business serving the city.
- It is a proposal, not yet a rule. A hearing is set for 19 November. The notice gives a 19 November comment deadline; the city's rules website shows 18 December.

> Our view: if adopted, the reports would count a contact as resolved only with no transfer and no repeat within 72 hours. Someone would also have to staff the human queue to a stated wait. Watch: which comment deadline holds.

SOURCES New York City, 20 Oct · Gothamist, 20 Oct

THE BUYER

Comcast’s finance chief says it removed more than 30 million service contacts, and names its AI suppliers.

- Comcast’s finance chief, Jason Armstrong, said on its results call on 22 October that customer-service contact rates fell “roughly 20%” this year, Deadline reports.
- He said Comcast “eliminated more than 30 million service interactions year to date”, Deadline reports. The Philadelphia Inquirer reports he called its work with Cresta and Sierra “central to our new operating model”.
- Comcast plans job cuts in its broadband and wireless business and a charge of more than $1 billion next quarter, the Los Angeles Times reports, citing Bloomberg. No job number was given.
- The Inquirer says executives did not directly address layoffs on the call. Its sources say cuts are expected and some have started.

> Our view: a very large buyer now ties lower contact volume to named AI suppliers. Its measure is contacts avoided, not problems solved.

SOURCES Deadline, 22 Oct · Philadelphia Inquirer, 22 Oct · Los Angeles Times, 22 Oct

ZOOM

Zoom joins human and AI work, and puts role-play practice inside quality.

- At its Zoomtopia event on 20 October, Zoom launched a “Unified Context Layer”. Zoom says it “gives human and AI agents a shared memory of the customer”.
- Zoom says its quality product can now score whole cases across agents and back-office teams, including work in other vendors’ systems, and that this is available now.
- Zoom’s new “Quality Management AI Roleplay” lets agents practise calls before taking them, assessed on criteria such as empathy and policy adherence. Zoom says it is available now.
- CX Foundation, a trade site, reports a new Zoom pricing model: one yearly spending pool for agents, seats, apps and AI. Zoom’s own releases do not mention it.

> Our view: AI role-play practice now comes inside a large suite’s quality product. Specialist training vendors lose one more point of difference.

SOURCES Zoom, 20 Oct · CX Foundation, 20 Oct

SALESFORCE PRICES

Salesforce lists European prices and two new per-user add-ons.

- Salesforce's UK and EU contact-centre pages now show local prices: £100 or €125 per user a month, and £200 or €250 with workforce and quality management. On 18 October they showed none.
- Its price page now lists a quality management add-on at $50, £40 or €50 per user a month. Salesforce says it reviews "100% of human and AI agent interactions".
- Its AI price page now lists an "Agentforce Coworker User License", an assistant for staff, at $50 per user a month. Neither add-on was listed on 18 October.
- The customer-facing AI price is unchanged at $2 per conversation.

> Our view: Salesforce now charges per user for staff tools and per use for AI that serves customers. It prices scoring of its AI agents per human user.

SOURCES Salesforce price and overview pages, 25 Oct · Salesforce Agentforce pricing, 25 Oct

THE SCHEDULE

Microsoft dates a plan for scheduling software that acts by itself.

- Microsoft added an “Intraday Agent” to its public roadmap on 20 October. Microsoft says it “Automates corrective actions such as adjusting schedules, rescheduling breaks, or reallocating service representatives”.
- It is listed as in development, with general availability in March 2027. The entry also lists a September public preview; we found no public preview page.
- Microsoft’s October intraday features, volume-spike alerts and a performance report, were still “In development” on 25 October. Its documentation says the alerts “don’t reroute conversations, change staffing, or modify the published schedule.”
- Microsoft names Verint, Genesys and Calabrio among the vendors a shipped scheduling feature helps customers move from.
- Aspect says its rule-based automatic updates made 64.2% and 55.7% of schedule updates in two anonymous customer cases. Analysts still review flagged events, it says.

> Our view: a large vendor has now dated scheduling software that acts by itself. Every shipped tool we track still alerts, suggests or flags when demand shifts. Watch: whether Microsoft’s October features ship by month-end.

SOURCES Microsoft roadmap, 20 Oct · Microsoft Learn · Aspect, 21 Oct

THE RULES

Workplace AI rules: a vendor's emotion-AI advice and new UK shift protections.

- Aspect says the EU AI Act prohibits inferring agents' emotions from their voice or facial expressions. It advises "limiting emotion detection to the customer's side of the call". It is advice, not a product change.
- We found no contact-centre vendor renaming, limiting or switching off an emotion, sentiment or wellbeing feature. Zoom says its new case scoring analyses sentiment.
- The UK government said on 22 October that from March 2027, dismissing and rehiring staff to move them onto nights or weekends will be automatically unfair.
- Colorado's Attorney General published a cost analysis of its proposed AI rules on 21 October, with no cost figures. The hearing opens on 26 October; comments stay open until it ends.

> Our view: pressure on emotion features is arriving through vendor advice and buyers' contracts, not enforcement. Watch: California's emotion-AI ban, which starts on 1 January 2027.

SOURCES Aspect, 20 Oct · Zoom, 20 Oct · GOV.UK, 22 Oct · Colorado, 21 Oct · Davis Wright Tremaine

THE PREDICTIONS

Our check of the annual report's 18 predictions: no change, 12 supported.

- Our assessment: twelve supported, one showing early signs, one mixed, two weakened, one unchanged and one not triggered. No assessment changed since the last check on 3 October.
- Closest to changing: autonomous intraday scheduling. Microsoft's dated plan argues for an upgrade. It stays weakened: Lorikeet's 9 October promise has not appeared, and no shipped tool we track acts by itself when demand shifts.
- New York's proposal would make resolution counts reportable, while Comcast counts contacts avoided. Completion replacing deflection stays supported, with qualifications.
- The disproof test is not triggered: no tracked vendor moved from per-resolution pricing back to per-seat pricing. Salesforce held its $2 per conversation.

> These are our assessments, combining this week's developments with earlier evidence.

SOURCES ProductBeacon Research, 25 Oct

SOURCES

Sources behind this week's news.

Company announcements, official records and reporting cited on these slides:

COMPANY ANNOUNCEMENTS

Microsoft · Zoom · Salesforce · Aspect · Lorikeet

OFFICIAL RECORDS

New York City (consumer agency and rules site) · GOV.UK (UK government) · Colorado (Attorney General)

PRESS REPORTING AND LEGAL ANALYSIS

CXM · Gothamist · Deadline · Philadelphia Inquirer · Los Angeles Times · CX Foundation · Davis Wright Tremaine

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Source links are in the full weekly summary. Full claim-by-claim citations on request.

FULL DISCLOSURE

Microsoft brings its AI to rivals' platforms. New York proposes a route to a human.

Microsoft opened a public preview of its contact-centre AI for other vendors' contact centres, billed on usage credits, it says. New York City proposed, but has not adopted, a rule requiring a one-step route to a human. Our view: a large vendor has now dated scheduling software that acts by itself.

→ Read the full report

productbeacon.agency/research/state-of-wem-2026

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